

Testing Mischief

Monkey business at its best at the Digit Test Centre

The folks at the Digit Test Centre are usually a quiet lot—they sit in their large quadrangle-type room, where they tinker with motherboards, RAM chips and monitors with the same delight of a kindergarten kid playing with crayons.

But imagine the delight of the Test Centre folks when they asked several consumer electronics and IT hardware companies to send in their entertainment products for testing. While comparing their glee to giggly schoolgirls discussing their latest plaything would be inappropriate, their excitement was nothing less than what NASA scientists experience soon after they see Mars Rover spacecraft.

Nevertheless, once the products arrived—7.1 speaker systems, a Media Center PC, DVD players, an Internet radio, a 5.1 headphone set, a LCD TV, and TV tuner cards - these guys got back to their work with the seriousness of an Andrew Wiles trying to solve Fermat's Last Theorem.

... Or so it seemed

Mysteriously, they never came out to talk to people, or lunch with them, or even play table tennis—Digit's favourite pastime whenever they are stressed or want to escape the boss. Strangely enough, some sounds began to emanate from the usually pin-drop-silence TC zone. And boy, were they sounds or what!

A U2 Live Concert DVD on a seven-channel speaker system was by far the most popular entertainment option. But not once did they ever say to us: "Wish you were here." And since they were huddled around the speakers for most part of the day (and sometimes well into the night), the others felt the TC should change its anthem to *Goodbye, blue sky*, Pink Floyd's most evocative anti-war song.

But surely, the TC was indeed like a war zone, with most Digit team members trying a get piece of the entertainment pie. One person wanted to watch Tom Cruise's *Minority Report*, while others wanted the other Tom—the one who goes around with the Hanks surname—in his Oscar-winning *Forrest Gump*.

Those with a quiet demeanour settled



Mahesh Benkar

for the 5.1 surround headphones with three jacks. One for the rear effect, one for the front, and one for the centre speaker. Even the traditionally-ignored stereo headphones were in demand.

In between, the bigger audiophiles among the group would switch on DVD audio, making music listening truly divine.

The story does not end here. There were other interesting products being tested this month—such as the Handspring Treo 180 and the Nokia 6600, a camera phone that can surprise the most hardened cynics with its features. Deepak Dhingra, who heads the Test Centre, and who grew a natty French beard to complement his 'newly-acquired 6600', went around clicking candid photos that even our in-house professional cameraperson Mexy Xavier would be proud of.

Another phone, the flip-model BenQ, was with Sachin Kalbag, who styles himself as this magazine's features editor. As a full-fledged, card-carrying member of

the Boys With Toys club, Sachin even played a prank on his wife telling her he bought a Rs 10k phone just for the heck of it. She promptly threatened to not speak to him for an unspecified period. Thankfully, the said period was just 10 hours.

Meanwhile assistant editor, Sumod Hajela, went around flaunting the Handspring Treo 180 for a day or two, until he found out that Handspring has actually discontinued the model in the US, but a few importers have been bringing the model to India only recently. He would then strategically hide it, determined to now flaunt a Treo only if the model number was 600, a current favourite in the US.

The month of February was an eventful one for most people at the Test Centre, thanks to the consumer electronics and IT entertainment products bonanza. We already hear that the engineers in there have put in a requisition for 72-inch home theatre systems. Wait till they get that! ■